



FINLAND

Capital city: Helsinki**Area:** 130,127 sq miles
(337,030 sq km)**Population:** 4,998,478**Official languages:**
Finnish, Swedish**Major religions:** Christian
91%, other 9%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Euro**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 78 years**People per doctor:** 323**Televisions:** 640 per 1,000
people

FINLAND

KNOWN AS “SUOMI” to its people, Finland is the most northerly independent country in the world. An aerial view of this land would show a spectacular pattern of forests, swampy peatland, massive lakes, and islands – scattered in the lakes and along the coastline. Most of it is covered with pine, spruce, and birch trees, and for up to half of the year it is carpeted with snow. After centuries of Swedish rule, Finland became part of Russia before independence in 1917. Finland has a distinctive language and culture that marks it apart from the rest of Scandinavia.



LOGGING INDUSTRY

Lumber is a major industry in this forested country – Finland and Sweden are Europe’s top producers of the softwoods pine and spruce. The lumber is transported by truck to processing plants where the wood is boiled down to a pulp. The liquid produced, wood alcohol, is used in various chemicals, while the pulp is made into plywood, board, and paper. Sawdust, bark, and waste are burned to produce electricity.



LAPLAND

The icy north of Norway, Sweden, and Finland is called Lapland. The people who live in the scattered villages of this region, the Sami, or Lapps, have their own language and customs. Some herd reindeer for their meat and milk. However, their traditional way of life is slowly changing. Lapland is also known as the home of Santa Claus, and thousands of children send letters to him there each year.

HELSINKI

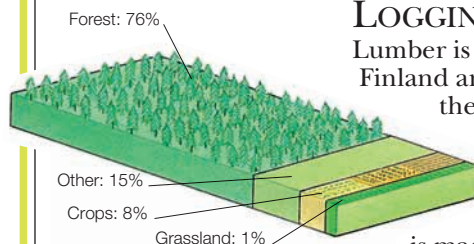
Surrounded on three sides by water, Finland’s capital, Helsinki, has an open, spacious feel. Its magnificent harbor boasts a colorful street market selling fish, fruit, vegetables, and flowers. The city is filled with exciting modern buildings that are designed to blend with the old, creating a distinctive national style.



SAUNAS

Finland is the home of the sauna. The Finns have used these steam baths for centuries, and today most houses in Finland have one. A sauna is a small, very warm room that people sit in to relax and cleanse their bodies. From time to time they throw water over hot stones and, as the water crackles and spits, the air fills with clouds of steam. Most families enjoy a shared sauna every week.

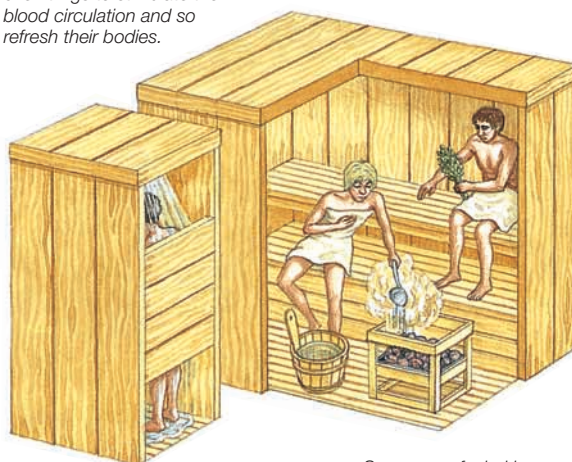
What the land is used for



LAND OF LAKES

Well over 50,000 lakes take up about 10 percent of the country’s area and are a major tourist attraction. Lake Saimaa is the largest lake and contains hundreds of islands. Ferries provide a vital link between the coastal islands. During the long, cold winters, lakes may freeze up and icebreakers keep coastal waters open for merchant shipping.

People beat themselves with birch twigs to stimulate their blood circulation and so refresh their bodies.



After a session in the sauna, it is time to cool off under a cold shower – or in the nearby lake!

Saunas are fueled by wooden logs in the country and by electricity in towns and cities.

Find out more

ARCTIC PEOPLES: 25, 266
LOGGING: 26, 69, 244
NORTHERN FORESTS:
15, 132